

lives) in order to indulge in my favorite activity, being a flâneur.

My Mistakes

And of course people will scrutinize the text. After examining messages and reports, I do not feel I need to retract anything in the initial version, or to correct any error (outside of typos and minor factual mistakes), except for two related matters. The first fault was pointed out to me by Jon Elster. I had written that the narrative fallacy pervades historical analyses, since I believed that there was no such thing as a test of a historical statement by forecasting and falsification. Elster explained to me that there are situations in which historical theory can escape the narrative fallacy and be subjected to empirical rejection—areas in which we are discovering documents or archeological sites yielding information capable of countering a certain narrative.

So, in relation to his point, I realized that the history of Arabic thought was not so definitive and that I had fallen into the trap of ignoring the continuous changes in *past* history, that the past too was largely a prediction. I (accidentally) discovered that I had fallen for conventional wisdom in textbook scholarship on Arabic philosophy, a wisdom that was contradicted by existing documents. I had exaggerated the import of the debate between Averroës and Algazel. Like everyone I thought that 1) it was a big deal and, 2) it killed Arabic *falsafah*. It turned out to be one of the mis-conceptions being recently debunked by researchers (such as Dimitri Gutas and George Saliba). Most of those who theorized about Arabic philosophy did not know Arabic, so they left many things to their imagination (like Leo Strauss, for example). I am a bit ashamed, because Arabic is one of my native languages, and here I was reporting from tenth-hand sources developed by scholars illiterate in Arabic (and sufficiently overconfident and lacking in erudition to not realize it). I fell for the confirmation bias seen by Gutas: “It seems that one always starts with a preconception of what Arabic philosophy should be saying, and then concentrating only on those passages which seem to be supporting such a bias, thereby appearing to corroborate the preconception on the basis of the texts themselves.”

Once again, beware of history.

ROBUSTNESS AND FRAGILITY

Upon the completion of *The Black Swan*, I spent some time meditating on the items I raised in [Chapter 14](#) on the fragility of some systems with